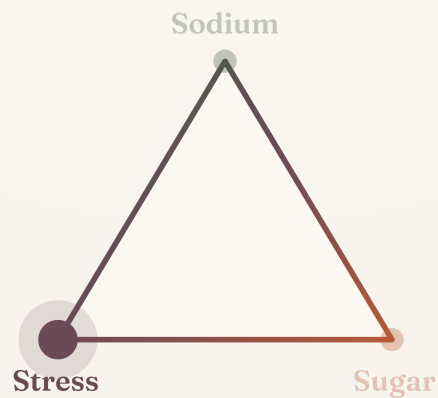


CORNER ONE OF THE BP TRIANGLE



The Stress Corner, 10-Day Reset

*Calm the cortisol that tightens your vessels and
tells your kidneys to hold sodium.*

by Joel Polley, RN

BRAVEWORKS RN . REGISTERED NURSE, NATUROPATHIC PRACTITIONER

THE BP TRIANGLE . STRESS . SUGAR . SODIUM

The STRESS Corner

The first corner of the BP Triangle Reset. 10 days. Author: Joel Polley, RN.

First, thank you. You showed up, and showing up is the part most people never do. If your quiz landed you here, it means stress is the loudest corner of your triangle right now, and that is good news, because it means we already know where to start.

The physiology (in plain English)

Here is the chain your body is running. Stress, real or remembered, triggers your adrenal glands to release a hormone called cortisol. Your body does not know the difference between a bear in the road and a 2 AM worry about money. It pumps out cortisol either way. And cortisol does two things that drive your blood pressure up.

First, it constricts your blood vessels. It makes your arteries tighten and lose their ability to relax, so the same blood has to push through narrower pipes. Higher pressure.

Second, it tells your kidneys to hold onto sodium. Cortisol enhances the aldosterone signal, so your kidneys reabsorb salt and water instead of releasing it. More fluid in the system means more volume pushing against your vessel walls. Higher pressure again.

There is a third thing, and it is the doorway to your next corner. Cortisol also spikes your blood sugar. It pulls glucose into your bloodstream for the emergency that never comes, and that chronic sugar load triggers insulin, which tells your kidneys to hold even more sodium. That is the hand-off. Stress feeds sugar, sugar feeds sodium, and the loop keeps turning. We will close it one corner at a time.

In a healthy body, cortisol rises, the threat passes, and cortisol falls. The system resets. The problem is not that your body makes cortisol. The problem is that modern life never lets it stop. The alarm is stuck on HIGH.

What you will do in these 10 days

We follow one simple shape: Find it, eliminate it, add what heals, supplement, then watch your body respond. Day 1 you name the cause and take your baseline. Days 2 and 3 you cut what is feeding the cortisol. Days 4 and 5 you add the keystone practice and the foods. Days 6 and 7 you bring in the herbs and start tracking. Days 8 and 9 you read the signals and watch the

number move. Day 10 you lock in your keystone habit and we hand you to the next corner. Nothing gets ripped away. Each day stacks on the one before it. Build over days, not hours. Consistency beats intensity.

A word before we start, and I mean this. This is education that walks alongside your doctor, never instead of your doctor. Nothing here replaces medical care, and you never stop or change a prescription on your own. Med changes are your doctor's call, made with your numbers in front of both of you. Our job is to give your body what it needs and let the data lead the conversation.

1 Day 1

FIND

Phase: FIND. Today's action: name the cause and draw your starting line.

You cannot fix what you have not named. So today we name it, and we take a baseline you can measure everything else against.

Here is the truth most people never get told. The exhaustion, the belly that will not budge, the anxiety that showed up out of nowhere, the 2 to 3 AM bolt-awake with your heart racing, the blood pressure climbing for no clear reason. These are not eight separate problems. They are one hormone running too high for too long. That hormone is cortisol, and naming it accurately is the first piece of power you get back. Stop calling it "just stress." Chronic cortisol elevation is a real, measurable, physiological condition, and it is addressable.

Do this today:

1. Take your blood pressure. Sit quietly for five minutes first, feet flat, back supported, same arm you will use every day. Take two or three readings a minute apart, discard the first, and average the rest. Write the number down. This is your baseline. No judgment, just data.
2. Rate your loudest signals right now on a 1 to 10 scale and write them down: sleep quality, waking energy, stress level, brain fog, anxiety. Note how many hours you slept last night and whether you woke in the night. These are your felt signals, and you will watch them move.
3. Re-read the physiology above and circle which symptoms apply to you. Seeing them as one root cause instead of fifteen is the moment this stops being confusing and starts making sense.

You are not broken. You are not weak. You are not "just getting older." You are carrying a cortisol load your body was never designed to carry without rest. Tomorrow we start taking that load off. Tonight, rest well. We are just getting started.

2 Day 2

ELIMINATE

Phase: ELIMINATE. Today's action: cut the number one input feeding your cortisol.

Yesterday you named the cause. Today you remove the single biggest thing feeding it. We do not add anything yet. One clear removal.

The number one cortisol trigger hiding in most people's day is the stimulant they reach for first thing in the morning: caffeine. I want to walk you through why, and then I want to ask you to set it down.

Caffeine triggers an adrenaline release, raises your heart rate, and constricts your blood vessels. It can spike blood pressure by 5 to 10 mmHg within thirty minutes of the cup. More than that, it pours fuel on a cortisol system that is already running hot. You are stacking a stimulant on top of a stress hormone that will not switch off. That is why the afternoon crash hits so hard. Your cortisol is simultaneously too high and your adrenals are depleted, and no amount of coffee fixes that. It deepens the hole.

Do this today:

- Cut the caffeine. Coffee, energy drinks, strong tea, soda. For the next stretch of this corner, set it down completely.
- Swap, do not just subtract. Reach for chamomile tea or hibiscus tea instead. Both actively lower blood pressure while you sip, so you are not white-knuckling a gap. You are trading up.
- If you have leaned on caffeine hard, expect a day or two of a dull headache as your body recalibrates. That is the stimulant leaving, not a sign you need it. Drink more water and walk it off.

Hear me clearly: cutting caffeine is a win, not a loss. You are handing your adrenals their first real break in years. Most people feel their sleep deepen within a few nights, and better sleep is the foundation everything else gets built on. You are not giving something up. You are giving your body permission to come back down.

3 Day 3

ELIMINATE

Phase: ELIMINATE. Today's action: strip the secondary inputs. Removal phase complete.

Yesterday you cut the biggest cortisol input. Today we strip the rest of the easy ones, and your removal phase is done. These are the small, silent triggers that keep the alarm ringing all night long.

Your cortisol is supposed to follow a clock. It should peak in the morning to wake you and fall to its lowest point overnight so your body can do its deep repair and your blood pressure can dip the way it is designed to. Chronic stress inverts that clock. Cortisol surges in the evening, gives you that wired second wind at 9 PM, suppresses your melatonin, and then bolts you awake at 2 or 3 AM with a racing heart. We are going to protect the evening so the clock can reset.

Pick the ones you have not handled and execute them tonight:

- **No screens after 9 PM.** The blue light and the stimulation hold cortisol up and push melatonin down right when it should be rising. Power down.
- **No news or social media in the last hour before bed.** Your hypothalamus cannot tell the difference between a real threat and a doom-scroll. Every alarming headline fires the same cortisol cascade. Close the apps.
- **No alcohol as a wind-down.** It feels sedating, but it activates the sympathetic nervous system a few hours later and is a common cause of the middle-of-the-night wake-up.
- **Cool and dark the room.** A cooler, fully dark room supports the melatonin window and deeper sleep stages.

Do this today: Choose the items above that still apply to you and put them in place starting tonight. Write down which ones you committed to so you can hold yourself to them.

That is the whole removal phase. You have stopped pouring fuel on the fire. From here on we stop subtracting and start adding the things that actively bring cortisol down. Well done. The hardest part is behind you.

4 Day 4

ADD

Phase: ADD (practice). Today's action: add the keystone calming practice for this corner.

The removal phase is complete. Now we add. Today you get the single most important practice for this corner, and it is one you carry in your own body and can use anywhere, for free, for the rest of your life.

It is slow, deliberate breathing, and it is not a mood trick. It is physiology. Here is the mechanism. Your vagus nerve is the main cable of your rest-and-recover nervous system, the off-switch to the fight-or-flight overdrive that chronic cortisol keeps jammed on. Slow breathing with a long exhale activates that nerve directly. It tells your heart to slow, your vessels to relax, and your cortisol to start dropping. You are reaching in and flipping the switch your stress response refuses to flip on its own.

Do this today, and make it your keystone:

- **Box breathing.** Inhale through your nose for a count of 4, hold for 4, exhale for 4, hold for 4. Repeat for five minutes. Do one round mid-afternoon, when cortisol tends to spike, and one round before bed.
- **The bedtime off-switch.** As your head hits the pillow, take five slow breaths with a longer exhale than inhale: in for 4, hold for 4, out for 6. The long exhale is what pulls the vagus brake. This is your nightly signal to your body that the day is over and it is safe to power down.

Two more keystone-grade practices to weave in, because cortisol comes down through more than one door:

- **Get outside and walk in the morning sun.** A 20-minute unhurried walk in daylight does three things at once: it lowers cortisol, it sets your body clock so the cortisol curve falls correctly at night, and the sunlight itself supports the whole rhythm. Unhurried is the point. This is not exercise to conquer. It is rest in motion.
- **Pray or sit with Scripture.** Worry is a physiological cortisol generator. Every anxious thought fires the stress axis. Casting that worry, naming it and handing it over, engages the part of your brain that strengthens the cortisol brake. "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you" (1 Peter 5:7). Faith is not only spiritual here. It is physiological.

Anchor the breathing as the practice you do every single day. The rest stacks on top.

5 Day 5

ADD

Phase: ADD (foods). Today's action: add the healing foods that bring cortisol down and open your vessels.

You have the practice. Today you add the food, because what you put on your plate either calms this system or inflames it. We are going plant-forward and whole-food, the way your body was designed to be fed.

The goal of today is twofold. Feed the foods that lower cortisol and reduce inflammation, and feed the foods that restore nitric oxide, your body's master signal for relaxing arteries. Cortisol suppresses nitric oxide hard, which is a big part of why your vessels stay tight. We put it back through the plate.

Do this today:

- **Build meals from whole, plant-based ingredients.** Vegetables, fruit, beans, lentils, whole grains, nuts, and seeds. This is anti-inflammatory eating, and inflammation is one of the pathways cortisol uses to damage your vessel walls. Cook from real ingredients rather than packaged food.
- **Add raw garlic.** Crush two cloves, let them sit ten minutes so the active compound forms, then take them with your largest meal. Garlic supports nitric oxide and works on several blood-pressure pathways at once.
- **Lean on nitric-oxide foods.** Beets and beet juice, leafy greens, and garlic all stimulate the nitric oxide your cortisol has been suppressing. This is how you give your arteries back the ability to relax.
- **Magnesium-rich foods.** Leafy greens, pumpkin seeds, beans, and nuts. Barbara O'Neill calls magnesium "the relaxation mineral," and she is right. It is involved in over 300 functions in the body, and chronic stress burns through it fast. Here is the mechanism Walt Cross teaches, and it is worth sitting with: when you are stressed, the body dumps magnesium to protect the cells from adrenaline. So the more stress you carry, the more of your relaxation mineral you lose, right when you need it most. Magnesium is the one most depleted by chronic stress and the one most people with high blood pressure are short on. We will add it as a supplement on Day 6, and the food groundwork starts today.

One quiet but powerful note on protein. Industrially raised animals live in chronic stress, and the cortisol and adrenaline in their bloodstream at slaughter end up in the meat. When you eat the biochemistry of a stressed animal, you take on the same hormones that raise your own pressure. Leaning into a plant-based plate removes that hidden load entirely. Your plate becomes part of the medicine.

Keep yesterday's breathing and walking going. Today the kitchen joins the team.

6 Day 6

SUPPLEMENT

Phase: SUPPLEMENT. Today's action: introduce this corner's herbs, one at a time, with safe dosing and caution.

The cause is removed, the practice is in, the foods are on the plate. Now we add the targeted botanical support. These are nature's tools for a cortisol system stuck on high, and every one of them below is in the Formulary at the end of this corner with its full detail. Read that section before you start.

The rule that matters most: add ONE herb at a time, and check your blood pressure daily so you can see what each one does for you. This is exactly how a careful clinician layers in support, watching the response before adding the next lever.

Start here today:

- **Magnesium glycinate, 300 to 400 mg, taken with dinner or before bed.** Start with this one. This is the relaxation mineral Barbara O'Neill talks about, the one involved in over 300 functions in your body and the one chronic stress has been quietly draining (remember Day 5: when you are stressed, the body dumps magnesium to protect the cells from adrenaline). Replacing it corrects the most common deficiency in people with high blood pressure, it calms the nervous system through your GABA pathway, and it tends to deepen sleep within the first few nights. Glycinate is the gold-standard form for absorption and calm. Avoid magnesium oxide, which your body barely absorbs. Alongside the capsule and the magnesium-rich foods, add a warm Epsom-salt bath in the evening: dissolve a cup or two of Epsom salt (which is magnesium) in the water and soak for twenty minutes. It is a NEWSTART-friendly wind-down ritual that pairs perfectly with your bedtime breathing and signals your body that the day is over.

A note before we go further, because this one matters. Magnesium is the throughline mineral of your whole triangle, the single thread that runs through more than one corner. You are meeting it here in the STRESS corner, where it relaxes your nervous system, lowers cortisol, and deepens your sleep. You will meet it again in the SODIUM corner, where the very same mineral relaxes the smooth muscle in your blood-vessel walls so your arteries can open. Same mineral, two corners, two jobs. When a remedy keeps showing up across the triangle, pay attention, because that is your body telling you what it has been missing all along.

Then, after a few days on magnesium, add the keystone adaptogen:

- **Ashwagandha, 300 to 600 mg of a KSM-66 or Sensoril extract, once daily with food, in the morning or early afternoon.** This is the cortisol crusher. In a gold-standard randomized trial it lowered serum cortisol by 28 to 30 percent. Because cortisol drives every one of your pressure pathways at once, bringing it down 28 to 30 percent eases all of them together. Start at 300 mg for the first week, then move to 600 mg if you tolerate it. The full cortisol effect builds over 2 to 4 weeks, so be patient and consistent. Many people feel calmer and sleep better within the first few days.

The safety conversation, in plain terms:

- If you take blood pressure medication, these herbs can lower your pressure further. That is the goal, but it must happen with monitoring. Check your BP daily. If readings run consistently low, below about 110/70, or you feel dizzy or lightheaded, contact your doctor about your medication dose. Do not adjust medication on your own. Let the data guide that conversation.
- **Ashwagandha:** avoid if you are pregnant or nursing, and use caution if you have a thyroid condition, since it can raise thyroid hormone. Run it by your doctor first if that is you.
- Tell your doctor everything you are adding. Always.

Add slowly. Watch the numbers. Two herbs in is plenty for today.

7 Day 7

SUPPLEMENT + MONITOR

Phase: SUPPLEMENT plus MONITOR. Today's action: complete your calming stack and begin tracking your body's response.

Your full stress-corner stack goes into place today, and at the same time we start watching what your body is telling you. From here, you are not guessing. You are reading data.

Complete the stack, one addition at a time, only as your readings stay steady:

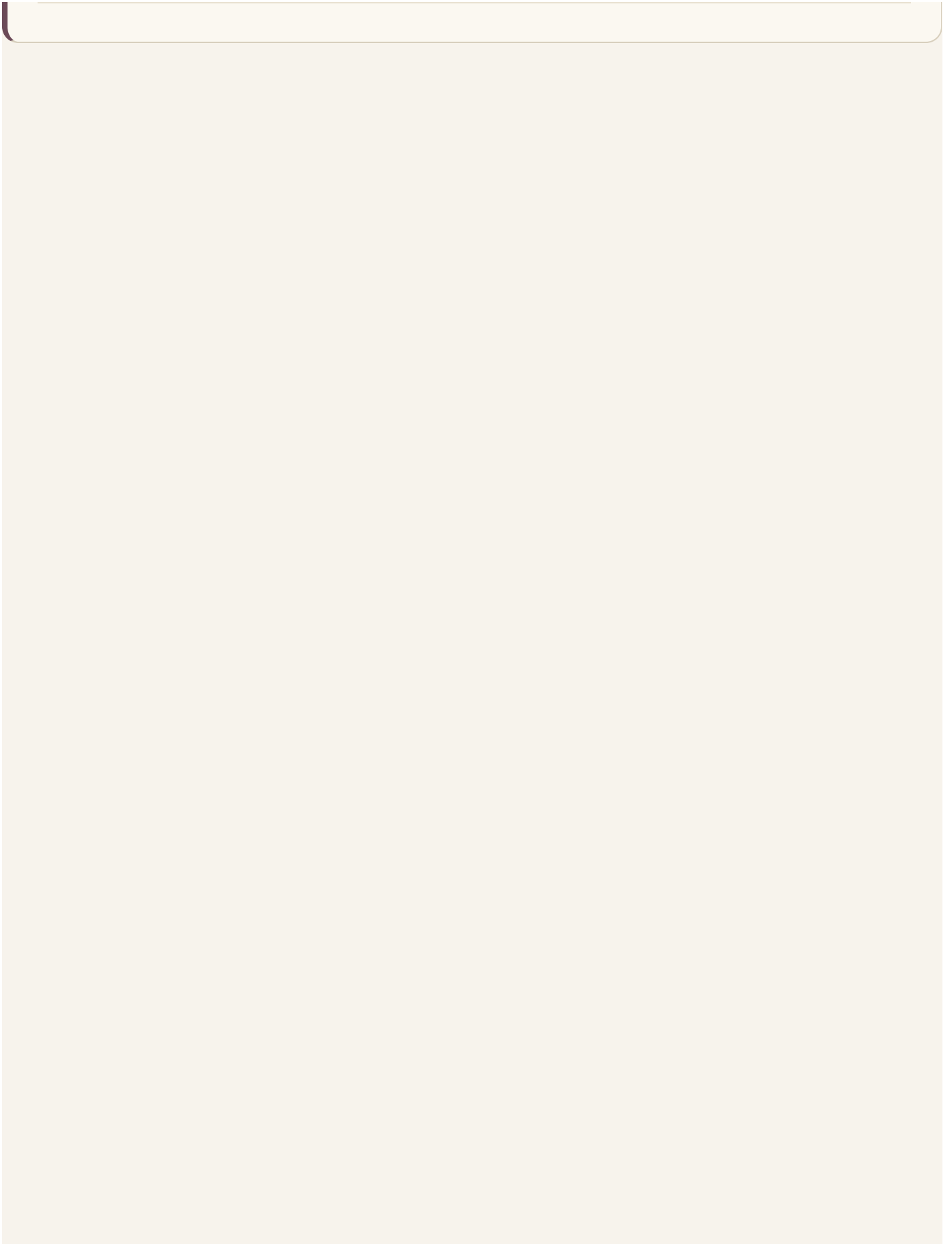
- **Tart cherry** in the evening, as a natural source of melatonin to support the sleep your cortisol has been stealing. Better sleep means a better overnight blood-pressure dip and more vascular repair.
- **Passionflower**, if anxiety and a racing, wired feeling are loud for you. It calms the sympathetic overdrive that drives your pressure up, working through the same GABA pathway, and it calms without heavy sedation.
- **Lemon balm**, a gentle calming herb that pairs well with passionflower for that keyed-up, can't-settle feeling.

Remember the discipline: one new thing at a time, BP checked daily, everything reported to your doctor. The full detail and cautions for each of these is in the Formulary below.

Now begin monitoring. Track these every day:

1. **Your morning blood pressure.** Same conditions every time: seated five minutes, same arm, two or three readings averaged. The single daily number is your anchor.
2. **Your felt signals, 1 to 10:** sleep quality, waking energy, anxiety, brain fog. Same five you scored on Day 1.
3. **The corner's signature signal: your sleep and your 2 to 3 AM wake-up.** Did you sleep through? Did you wake, and if so, did your heart race? This is the most sensitive early read on whether your cortisol is coming down, because the overnight surge is the first thing to settle.

Write it down daily. A note on your phone or a paper log both work. What you are building is a trend line, and the trend is where the truth lives. Tomorrow we read what it is starting to say.



8 Day 8

MONITOR

Phase: MONITOR. Today's action: read the signals and learn what moves first.

Today you do not add anything. You read. You have a few days of data now, and learning to interpret it is a skill that will serve you for the rest of your life. This is what it means to become the kind of person who understands her own body instead of waiting for someone else to interpret it.

Here is the order things tend to move, so you know what to look for.

Sleep usually shifts first. Within the first several nights of magnesium and the evening wind-down, most people notice they fall asleep faster, sleep deeper, or stop bolting awake at 2 to 3 AM. If your night-time wake-up is softening, that is a direct sign your overnight cortisol surge is calming down. This is the earliest and most reliable signal that the corner is working.

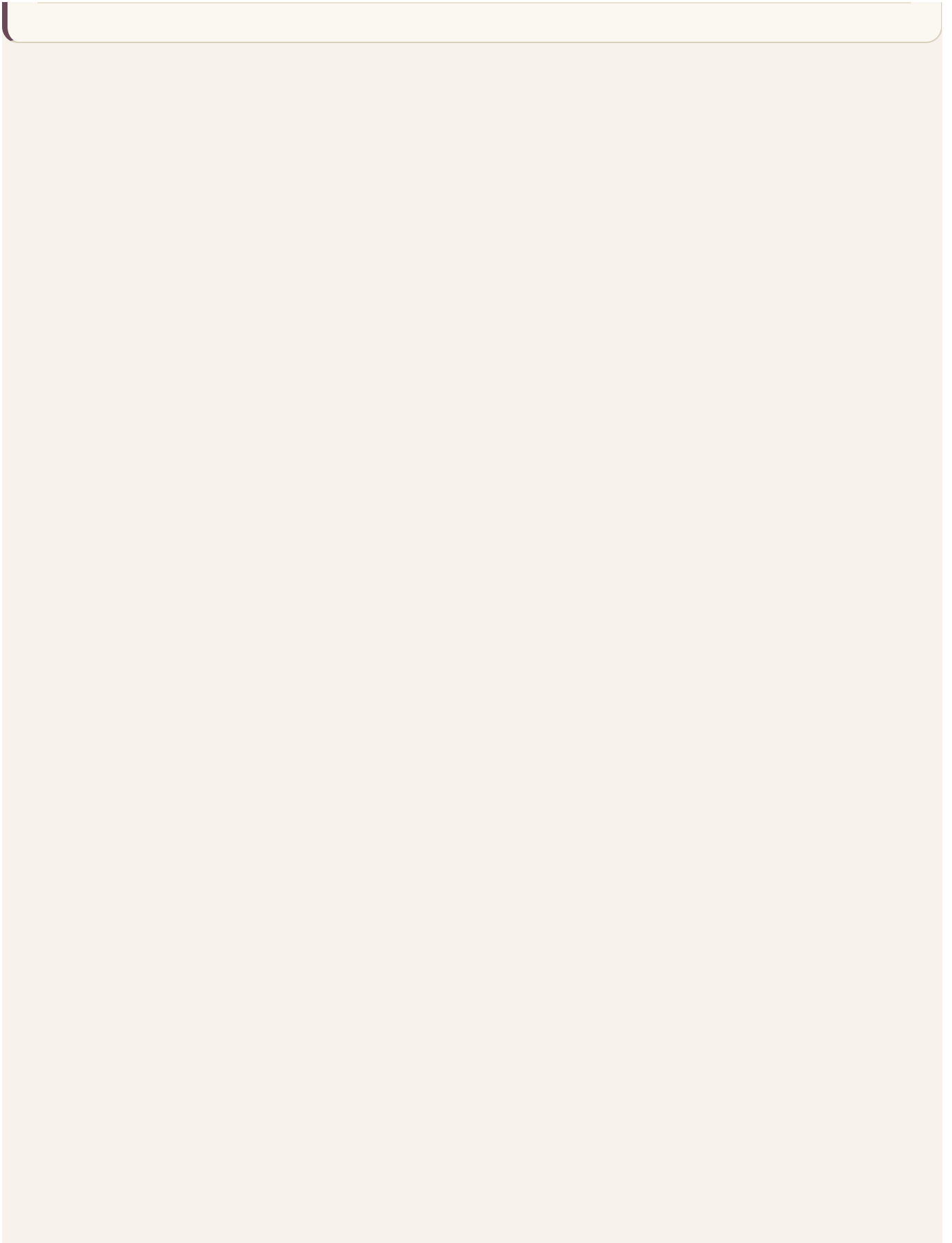
The felt signals move next. Waking energy starts to lift. The afternoon crash eases. The free-floating anxiety quiets a notch. Brain fog begins to clear. These are your nervous system stepping out of constant emergency mode.

Blood pressure follows. The number is often the last to move, and it moves on the trend, not day to day. Do not panic over a single high reading. Blood pressure changes with every breath, every emotion, every degree of temperature. One number is noise. The average over a week is signal.

Do this today:

- Look back across your readings since Day 7. Ask three questions. Is my sleep improving? Are my felt signals lifting? Is my BP trend, the average, starting to ease?
- Name what has moved first for you. Write it in one sentence: "My ___ is the first thing that changed."
- If nothing has moved yet, do not lose heart. Ashwagandha's full cortisol effect takes 2 to 4 weeks. You are days in. Stay consistent. The body keeps its appointments.

Reading your own signals is the opposite of anxious cuff-watching. You are gathering data with calm curiosity, not policing a number with fear. That shift in posture is part of the healing.



9 Day 9

WATCH IT HEAL

Phase: WATCH IT HEAL. Today's action: see the response and understand why it happened.

Today is the day you connect what you removed and added to what your body is doing, so you understand the why, not just the result. Because when you understand the mechanism, you own it, and no one can take that knowledge back.

Look at what has shifted since Day 1. Whatever has moved, whether it is deeper sleep, a calmer afternoon, fewer night-time wake-ups, or an easing BP trend, here is the chain of why behind it.

- You **cut the caffeine** and **protected your evenings**, so you stopped firing fresh cortisol into a system that was already overloaded. The alarm finally got some quiet.
- You **added slow breathing, morning sun, walking, and prayer**, so you actively engaged the brake on your stress response, the vagus and the prefrontal cortex, and pulled cortisol down instead of waiting for it to fall on its own.
- You **fed your body whole plants and nitric-oxide foods**, so you gave your arteries back the signal to relax that cortisol had been suppressing.
- You **added magnesium and ashwagandha**, so you corrected the deficiency stress had created and reduced cortisol output at the source by up to 28 to 30 percent.

Every one of those moves the same direction: less cortisol means less vasoconstriction, less sodium retention, less sympathetic overdrive, and a clearer overnight repair window. You did not mask a number. You removed the drive behind it. That is the whole difference between management and healing.

Do this today:

- Write down your single biggest win since Day 1, in one sentence. Make it concrete: "I slept through the night three times this week," or "My morning average dropped from ___ to ___."
- Notice that your body did this. You did not force it. You removed what was harming it and gave it what it needed, and it knew how to come back. Your body was built to heal. You gave it permission to start.

Sit with that for a moment. This is what trusting your body, instead of fearing it, feels like. Tomorrow we lock it in and open the next corner.

10 Day 10

CLOSE PLUS LOOP BRIDGE

Phase: CLOSE plus LOOP BRIDGE. Today's action: lock in your keystone habit, then cross into the SUGAR corner.

You did it. Ten days ago stress was the loudest corner of your triangle, and you walked straight at it. You named it, you cut what fed it, you added what heals it, you supported your body, and you watched it respond. Take a breath and let that land. Most people never get this far.

First, lock in your keystone.

You added a lot in ten days. You do not need to white-knuckle all of it forever. You need ONE non-negotiable habit from this corner that holds the gain for life. For the stress corner, that keystone is your **daily breathing-and-wind-down ritual**: box breathing in the afternoon, the long-exhale breaths at bedtime, screens off by 9. It costs nothing, it travels with you, and it keeps your vagus brake strong and your cortisol clock on time. Pick your exact daily version of it today and commit to it as the one stress habit you keep no matter what. Build the rest of your stack around that anchor.

Now, the bridge. Here is how this corner feeds the next one.

Remember the third thing cortisol does. It does not only constrict your vessels and hold sodium. It also spikes your blood sugar. Cortisol pumps glucose into your bloodstream for an emergency that never comes, and over time that drives insulin resistance. And insulin, just like cortisol, tells your kidneys to hold onto sodium. So your stressed body and your sugar-strained body are pushing your pressure up through the very same door, and they are amplifying each other.

That is why we cannot stop here. The triangle is a loop. You just calmed the stress corner, but if blood sugar is still spiking, it keeps feeding pressure right back in, and it even feeds cortisol in return. You have to travel the whole loop to close it.

So tomorrow we step into the **SUGAR corner**. Same shape you now know by heart: find it, eliminate it, add the practice, add the foods, supplement, monitor, watch it heal. You already learned the method. Now you apply it to the next driver. Calm all three corners and your numbers come home.

Well done on the first corner. Rest well tonight. The breathing you locked in starts now, and tomorrow the journey continues.

Formulary: The Stress Corner Herbs

A quick reference. Add ONE at a time, check your blood pressure daily, and tell your doctor everything you are taking.

These are Joel's adrenal and calming herbs for the stress corner, harvested from the BP Reset Kit and the Cortisol Cure materials. Education only, alongside your doctor, never instead of your doctor. The universal rule: add ONE at a time, check your blood pressure daily, and tell your doctor everything you are taking. If you are on BP medication, these can lower your pressure further (that is the goal, under monitoring); if readings run consistently below about 110/70 or you feel dizzy, call your doctor about your medication dose. Never stop or change a prescription on your own.

1. Ashwagandha (*Withania somnifera*): the keystone cortisol reducer

- **What it does:** Adaptogen that calms the HPA axis, the master stress-response system, and reduces cortisol output. Also supports endothelial function (how well vessels expand).
- **Dose:** 300 to 600 mg daily of a KSM-66 or Sensoril standardized extract, with food, morning or early afternoon. Start at 300 mg for the first week, increase to 600 mg if tolerated.
- **Evidence:** Gold-standard randomized, double-blind, placebo-controlled trial showed a 28 to 30 percent reduction in serum cortisol. Full cortisol effect builds over 2 to 4 weeks; calmer mood and better sleep often appear within days.
- **Caution:** Avoid if pregnant or nursing. May raise thyroid hormone levels, so use caution and check with your doctor if you have a thyroid condition. Tell your doctor if you take any sedative or thyroid medication.

2. Magnesium glycinate: the relaxation mineral and the throughline of the whole triangle

- **What it does:** Barbara O'Neill calls magnesium "the relaxation mineral," and it earns the name. It is involved in over 300 functions in the body, and chronic stress depletes it fast. Walt Cross explains the mechanism plainly: when you are stressed, the body dumps magnesium to protect the cells from adrenaline, so the harder your life runs, the more of this mineral you lose. Replacing it calms the nervous system through the GABA pathway, supports sleep, and acts as a natural calcium-channel relaxant for blood vessels. It corrects the deficiency most

common in people with high blood pressure and chronic stress. This is the one supplement that works in more than one corner of your triangle: here in STRESS it relaxes the nervous system, lowers cortisol, and deepens sleep; in the SODIUM corner the same mineral relaxes the smooth muscle of your blood-vessel walls so your arteries can open. It is the connective thread of the whole 30 days.

- **Dose:** 300 to 400 mg daily, taken with dinner or before bed. Glycinate is the gold-standard form for absorption and calm. Magnesium taurate is also excellent for cardiovascular support. Avoid magnesium oxide (only about 4 percent absorbed).
- **Delivery beyond the capsule:** Lead with food (leafy greens, pumpkin seeds, beans, nuts) and the supplement above. You can also add an **Epsom-salt bath** (Epsom salt is magnesium sulfate): dissolve a cup or two in a warm bath and soak for about twenty minutes in the evening. It is a NEWSTART-friendly wind-down that pairs naturally with your bedtime breathing.
- **Evidence:** Meta-analysis support for 300 to 500 mg per day reducing blood pressure; deficiency present in more than half of people with hypertension.
- **Caution:** If you take a calcium-channel blocker such as amlodipine, combining adds to the same mechanism and needs daily monitoring. Citrate forms can loosen stools. Magnesium is cleared by the kidneys, so if you have reduced kidney function or kidney disease, talk with your doctor before supplementing and let your readings and your doctor guide the dose.

3. Tart cherry: the sleep restorer

- **What it does:** Natural source of melatonin to support sleep onset and quality. Better sleep means a deeper overnight blood-pressure dip and more vascular repair, which is exactly the window chronic cortisol steals.
- **Dose:** Taken in the evening. (Joel's source lists tart cherry as the sleep-support pairing with magnesium glycinate; it does not specify a milligram dose for this corner. Follow product labeling and your doctor's guidance for the exact amount.)
- **Evidence:** Cited alongside magnesium glycinate for regulating sleep through the GABA system and improving sleep time and quality.
- **Caution:** Generally gentle. As with all of these, introduce one at a time and tell your doctor.

4. Passionflower: the sympathetic calmer

- **What it does:** Modulates GABA receptors to calm the sympathetic ("fight-or-flight") nervous system and reduce the adrenaline surge that drives blood pressure up. Joel's materials list it as the natural counterpart to the beta-blocker pathway. Calming without heavy sedation.

- **Dose:** Joel's source describes passionflower's mechanism and use for anxiety-related blood pressure but does not specify a milligram dose. Follow product labeling and your doctor's guidance for the exact amount, and add it only after your foundation herbs are steady.
- **Evidence:** Clinical evidence for anxiety-related hypertension; works on the same nervous-system targets as adrenaline-blocking medication.
- **Caution:** Can add to the effect of sedatives and blood-pressure medication. Introduce alone, monitor daily, and tell your doctor, especially if you take any calming or sleep medication.

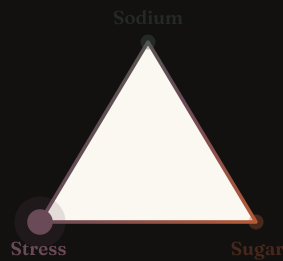
5. Lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*): the gentle settler

- **What it does:** A gentle calming herb listed in Joel's materials alongside the nervous-system-calming botanicals; pairs well with passionflower for a keyed-up, cannot-settle feeling.
- **Dose:** Joel's source names lemon balm as a calming natural counterpart but does not specify a milligram dose for this corner. Follow product labeling and your doctor's guidance for the exact amount.
- **Evidence:** Listed among the calming, sympathetic-soothing herbs in the BP Reset Kit's herb-to-medication comparison.
- **Caution:** Generally gentle; may add to sedative effects. As always, one at a time, monitor, and tell your doctor.

Daily non-herb supports (free, and the backbone of this corner)

- **Box breathing** (4-4-4-4) mid-afternoon, and **long-exhale breathing** (in 4, hold 4, out 6) at bedtime to activate the vagus nerve and pull cortisol down.
- **A 20-minute unhurried walk in morning sunlight** to lower cortisol and reset the cortisol clock.
- **Gratitude practice** (spoken or written) in the evening; gratitude measurably lowers cortisol.
- **Prayer and Scripture** to engage the prefrontal cortex and strengthen the cortisol brake. "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you" (1 Peter 5:7).
- **No caffeine** (swap to chamomile or hibiscus tea), **screens off by 9 PM, bed by 9:30, cool and dark room** to protect the melatonin window and the overnight BP dip.

Next corner: SUGAR. Cortisol spikes your blood sugar, insulin holds sodium, and the loop keeps turning. You learned the method here. Now you carry it forward.



A WORD FROM YOUR NURSE

Joel Polley, RN

I spent twenty years at the ICU and ER bedside, managing blood pressure and blood sugar from the crash-cart side of medicine. What I learned is simple, and it is why BraveWorks exists: when you remove the cause, the effect changes. That is not a health tip. It is a law of physics.

I am a registered nurse and a naturopathic practitioner, and I built the Triangle to put the why back in your hands, so a blood pressure reading stops being a verdict and starts being a conversation you understand. Everything here walks alongside your doctor, never instead of your doctor. Your data is your power. Your doctor is your ally.

Keep the loop closed. Go live it.

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